

Because of the emotional state he was in, Bud didn't hear what Sandi was really trying to say. All he heard was his wife saying she wished she had married someone else. In an attitude of resignation he asked, "Will you sign the power of attorney on the house, Sandi?"

"You didn't hear a word I said, did you?" she declared, amazed. Was that all he'd gotten out of what she'd said? "Yes, I'll sign so you can get your loans renewed. I don't want to hurt you; I just want us to be one, and we're not. But I can tell you this: When the bottom falls out of your business, your so-called friends are going to leave you high and dry. Then what are you going to do, turn and run too?"

"I have never run from anything in my life," Bud responded. "I believe the investments I have made are sound, and I'll stand by the people who have invested with me, no matter what."

"You may get a chance to find out what 'no matter what' is," Sandi said. "Some clients sue their financial advisers during a bad time in the real estate market. Yours will too."

"The people who invest with me know that I always try to do what's best for them," Bud said defensively. "I can't help what happens to interest rates. They know that."

"Get into the real world, Bud," she said. "Those people won't care if you spend twenty hours a day working for them. What most of them care about is that you sold them an investment that lost money."

Bud pledged their home as collateral against the bank loans and was able to hold off the foreclosures for the time being. But several months passed, and the economic situation didn't get any better. In fact, it got worse. Many of the biggest banks had hundreds of nonperforming loans and began to experience financial problems themselves. Loan managers were fired or moved, and new management was brought in to deal with the crisis. All real estate loans that had not been paid on in more than three months were immediately called as due and payable—Bud's included.